Name: _____ Class: _____ Date: _____

READING CHECK: "BISCUIT" AND "THE REEDS OF THE NORTH LAGOON"

Version A

Read the story and the article. Then answer each question. Fill in the circle next to the best answer.

Biscuit

Fiction · Written for this quiz.

1 Mrs. Abara handed Kiran her spare key and a page of notes. "Biscuit is shy with new people, so don't take it personally," she said. At the bottom she had written: Dev will come Thursday to water the plants. Kiran had asked his parents for a pet for three years. Four days with Biscuit felt like a test, and he planned to get a perfect score.

2 On Monday morning the apartment was silent. Kiran filled the bowl and crouched by the couch. "Here, kitty, kitty!" He shook the food bag and tapped the bowl with a spoon, louder each time. He walked to school with his shoulders up near his ears.

3 That evening the bowl was empty, and the blanket on the armchair was warm and covered in orange hair. Kiran looked behind the mat. Nothing had spilled. At dinner his sister Tam said, "So she ate!" Kiran shook his head. "Dev must have come by and tossed it out. She won't touch anything I give her."

4 On Tuesday he tried harder. He waved a feather toy under the bed and sang to her. Two green eyes watched him from the dark, then slid away. "She misses Mrs. Abara too much to eat," he told Tam. "And she hates me." Tam shrugged. "Or you're loud."

5 On Wednesday evening Kiran had a math test to study for and no energy for singing. He sat on the floor against the couch, opened his notebook, and forgot to call her at all.

6 After a while, something warm leaned against his elbow. Biscuit sat beside him, staring at the page as if she were checking his work. Kiran did not reach for her. He kept writing, but slower. She stayed until he finished the last problem.

7 On Thursday, Dev was watering the plants when Mrs. Abara got home. She glanced at Kiran's notebook. "I used to teach math, you know." Kiran started to say, "She didn't eat at first," then looked at Dev and stopped. Biscuit was curled on the armchair, watching him. "Could I come over sometimes?" he asked. "I'd bring my homework."

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Questions 1-5: "Biscuit"

1. In paragraph 1, how does Kiran feel about his four days with Biscuit?

A. nervous that Biscuit will not like him

B. sorry he agreed to watch someone else's cat

C. set on proving he can take care of a pet

D. sure the job will be easy and quick

2. In paragraph 5, why doesn't Kiran call Biscuit on Wednesday evening?

A. His mind is on the math test he has to study for.

B. He plans to ignore her so she will come to him.

C. Mrs. Abara's notes told him to leave her alone.

D. He has given up on ever winning Biscuit over.

3. Part A: Near the end of the story, why does Kiran stop in the middle of a sentence?

A. He remembers he was told not to take Biscuit's shyness personally.

B. He sees Biscuit watching him and does not want to upset her.

C. He sees that Biscuit must have eaten the food herself.

D. He does not want to blame Dev for the food in front of him.

4. Part B: Which quotation from the story BEST supports the answer to Part A?

A. "Biscuit is shy with new people, so don't take it personally," [1]

B. "Dev will come Thursday to water the plants." [1]

C. "On Monday, Dev's watering can sat by the empty bowl." [3]

D. "Biscuit was curled on the armchair, watching him." [7]

5. On Tuesday, what does Kiran try, and how does Biscuit respond? Quote the sentence that shows how she responds and give its paragraph number.

Answer: _____

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The Reeds of the North Lagoon

Nonfiction · Written for this quiz. Vessa Island, its people and its animals are invented.

1 Vessa Island has two shallow lagoons, North and South, with a strip of sand between them. Tall tolla reeds once grew thick along both shores. A long-legged gray bird called the drell nests only in thick reeds. At night it wades through the mud and eats kib snails.

2 In the winter of 1961, a storm flattened the reeds around the North Lagoon. The South Lagoon, behind higher dunes, lost only a few. With nowhere to nest, the North Lagoon's drells flew off. Some fishermen were glad. They believed drells ate young fish, though no one had ever seen one do it.

3 Everyone expected the reeds to come back in a year or two, as they had after smaller storms. They did not. Each spring, green shoots poked up from the mud, and each summer they were gone. Islanders blamed the salt the storm had washed in.

4 In 1968, a teacher named Hana Selk tested the North Lagoon's water and found it no saltier than the South's. Then she went out after dark with a lamp. The mud was crowded with kib snails, and they were eating the new shoots down to the roots. Without drells, almost nothing was eating the kibs.

5 The islanders first tried planting reeds by hand. The snails ate those too. So in 1971 Selk's students built wooden nesting platforms and hid them in the last reed clumps. Two pairs of drells moved in the next spring.

6 The change was slow. For five summers the shoots kept vanishing, and some islanders said the platforms were a waste of wood. By 1980, though, every platform was in use, the snails were thinner on the mud, and reeds stood again along the North Lagoon's shore.

7 The fishermen's catch did not drop when the drells came back. If anything, it rose. Young fish hide among reed stems.

8 Selk later wrote, "The storm knocked the reeds down. The missing birds kept them down."

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Questions 6-12: "The Reeds of the North Lagoon"

6. According to the article, when did the first drells move onto the platforms?

- **A.** the same summer the platforms were built
- **B.** five summers after the platforms were built
- **C.** in 1980, once the reeds stood again
- **D.** the spring after the platforms were built

7. Why did the drells most likely stay away from the North Lagoon for years after the storm?

A. The fishermen kept chasing them away.

B. Too few thick reeds were left for nesting.

C. Salt from the storm had killed the snails they ate.

D. There was too little food left for them to eat.

8. Based on the article, why did the North Lagoon's reeds stay away after 1961, when they had come back after smaller storms?

A. This storm drove off the birds the new shoots depended on.

B. This storm left salt in the water that never washed out.

C. This storm buried the roots under sand from the dunes.

D. This storm drove off the fish that ate the snails.

9. Part A: Why does the author tell about the islanders planting reeds by hand?

A. to show that new plants could not last while the snails went uneaten

B. to show that salt left by the storm still killed young plants

C. to show that planting by hand worked for a while

D. to show that the islanders did not want the drells back

10. Part B: Which quotation from the article BEST supports the answer to Part A?

A. "Islanders blamed the salt the storm had washed in." [3]

B. "By summer the planted reeds stood tall along the shore." [5]

C. "Some fishermen were glad." [2]

D. "The snails ate those too." [5]

11. Why does the author say Selk went out after dark?

A. to show she was searching for the drells that had left

B. to show the shoots were being eaten at night

C. to show that her water test had to be done at night

D. to show she did not want the fishermen to see her

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12. What does "thinner" mean as it is used in paragraph 6? Quote a sentence from an earlier paragraph that helps show the meaning, and give its paragraph number.

Answer: _____

CONSTRUCTED RESPONSE (4 points)

Write your answer on the lines.

13. How does Kiran change from the beginning of "Biscuit" to the end? Use RACE: R - Restate the question. A - Answer it. C - Cite two pieces of evidence with [paragraph numbers]. E - Explain how each piece of evidence proves your answer.

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